TAKING RESPONSIBILITY

Although we cannot predict the long-term evolution of the computer-based network over the coming centuries and millennia, we can nevertheless say something about how it is evolving right now, and that is far more urgent, because the rise of the new computer network has immediate political and personal implications for all of us. In the next chapters, we'll explore what is so new about our computer-based network and what it might mean for human life. What should be clear from the start is that this network will create entirely novel political and personal realities. The main message of the previous chapters has been that information isn't truth and that information revolutions don't uncover the truth. They create new political structures, economic models and cultural norms. Since the current information revolution is more momentous than any previous information revolution, it is likely to create unprecedented realities on an unprecedented scale.

It is important to understand this because we humans are still in control. We don't know for how long, but we still have the power to shape these new realities. To do so wisely, we need to comprehend what is happening. When we write computer code, we aren't just designing a product. We are redesigning politics, society and culture, and so we had better have a good grasp of politics, society and culture. We also need to take responsibility for what we are doing.

Alarmingly, as in the case of Facebook's involvement in the anti-Rohingya campaign, the corporations that lead the computer revolution tend to shift responsibility to customers and voters, or to politicians and regulators. When accused of creating social and political mayhem, they hide behind arguments like 'We are just a platform. We are doing what our customers want and what the voters permit. We don't force anyone to use our services, and we don't violate any existing law. If customers didn't like what we do, they would leave. If voters didn't like what we do, they would pass laws against us. Since the customers keep asking for more, and since no law forbids what we do, everything must be okay.'[47]

These arguments are either naive or disingenuous. Tech giants like Facebook, Amazon, Baidu and Alibaba aren't just the obedient servants of customer whims and government regulations. They increasingly shape these whims and regulations. The tech giants have a direct line to the world's